
GUINEA PIG

Cavia porcellus



Beginner

Complete Care Package

Quick Profile · Care Guide · Health · Quick Reference · Owner Tools

BeastlyFacts

Practical care guides for curious animal lovers

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How to Use This Package

This is a practical manual, not a textbook. Use the Quick Profile for a fast orientation, the Care Guide for day-to-day husbandry, and Health when something looks wrong. Owner Tools are designed to print and post near the enclosure.

This package is for educational purposes and is not a substitute for veterinary care. Guinea pigs hide illness well - when in doubt, contact a cavy-experienced exotic veterinarian.

Print these first

- Symptom quick reference (Health) - page 8
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1. Quick Profile

Guinea pigs (*Cavia porcellus*) are fully domesticated rodents descended from wild South American cavies. Andean peoples kept them for thousands of years; the modern pet form has no free-living wild population. They are social, vocal, and gentle, and they cannot synthesize vitamin C - a daily fresh-vegetable requirement that is non-negotiable for health.

Native Range	Domesticated from Andean wild cavies (Peru, Bolivia, Ecuador)
Natural Habitat	Fully domesticated; no wild modern population
Adult Size	8-12 in (20-30 cm); 1.5-2.6 lb
Wild / Natural Diet	Grasses, hay, leafy plants, vegetables
Typical Lifespan	4-8 years
Difficulty	Beginner (with correct diet and company)
Temperament	Social, vocal, gentle; best in pairs or groups

Fun Facts

- Guinea pigs use more than 11 distinct vocalizations to communicate, from food-wheeks to contented purrs.
 - Happy pigs often "popcorn" - leaping straight up and twisting mid-air for no reason other than joy.
 - Like humans, they cannot make their own vitamin C. Without daily fresh sources they develop scurvy.
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Cost Overview

Upfront setup for a pair typically runs \$100-250. That covers a solid-floor enclosure (often C and C style), bedding, hides, dishes, a water bottle, and starter hay and pellets. Shelter pigs are often \$10-60 each; specialty breeds cost more.

Monthly costs for a pair usually fall between \$60 and \$135, driven by hay, pellets, fresh vegetables, and bedding. Annual routine spending commonly lands near \$400-1,600 depending on diet quality and how often you see an exotic vet. Emergency visits for GI stasis or dental disease can exceed that quickly - correct husbandry is the cheaper path.

2. Full Care Guide

Housing & Enclosure

Minimum continuous floor space for a pair is commonly cited at about 10-13 square feet (many welfare sources treat 7.5 sq ft as an absolute floor and push higher). C and C-style cages with solid coroplast bases are popular because they scale cleanly. Never use wire-bottom cages - they cause bumblefoot and restrict natural movement. Provide at least one hide per pig plus one extra so no animal is trapped without an exit.



Example guinea pig enclosure layout (BeastlyFacts tank setup guide).

Temperature & Climate

Keep room temperature about 65-75°F. Avoid drafts and direct heat. Above roughly 80°F, heat stroke risk rises quickly - guinea pigs do not handle heat well. Cold, damp conditions raise respiratory infection risk. Place the enclosure away from windows in summer sun and away from AC vents that blast cold air.

Substrate & Furnishings

Use fleece liners (washed on a schedule) or paper-based bedding such as Carefresh. **Never** use cedar or pine shavings - aromatic oils damage the respiratory system and liver. Solid flooring only. Add multiple tunnels and hide houses, a hay rack or large hay pile, ceramic food dishes, and a water bottle or heavy bowl. A designated litter corner helps with cleaning.

Handling & Social Needs

Guinea pigs are highly social. A lone pig is at higher risk of depression and stress even with excellent human attention - plan for a compatible pair or small group. Handle gently with full body support; never grab from above like a predator. Learn the common sounds: wheeks (excitement/food), purrs (contentment), rumbles (dominance or courtship), and teeth chattering (annoyance). Daily supervised floor time in a pig-proofed area is excellent exercise and bonding.

Diet & Feeding

Unlimited grass hay is the foundation (about 70-80% of intake). Timothy, orchard, or meadow hay for adults; unlimited access every day for dental wear and gut motility. Offer a small measured amount of vitamin C-fortified, timothy-based pellets (about 1/8 cup per pig daily) - avoid seed-heavy or colorful mixes. Daily fresh vegetables are required because guinea pigs cannot make vitamin C. Bell pepper is an excellent daily source (about 1/4 medium pepper per pig); also use leafy greens such as kale, parsley, cilantro, and romaine. Do not rely on vitamin C water drops - they degrade quickly. Fresh water daily.

Common Mistakes to Avoid

- **Never** house on wire floors - bumblefoot and pain follow.
 - **Never** use cedar or pine shavings.
 - **Never** keep a guinea pig long-term as a solitary animal if a companion is possible.
 - **Never** skip daily vitamin C sources - scurvy is real and preventable.
 - **Never** treat unlimited hay as optional - dental disease is one of the top chronic problems.
 - **Never** ignore a pig that stops eating or stops producing droppings - same-day vet care.
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Enrichment

Guinea pigs are ground-dwelling foragers that spend most of their waking hours searching for food, chewing, and moving between secure hides. Enrichment is not optional decoration - it is how you let those behaviors happen in captivity.

Foraging & Food-Based Enrichment

Scatter a portion of daily pellets and chopped vegetables through hay instead of offering everything in a bowl. Stuff plain cardboard tubes (slit lengthwise so a pig cannot get stuck) with hay and a few leafy greens. Hide small veg pieces inside crumpled plain paper bags, egg cartons, or shallow boxes the pig must tear open. Use snuffle mats or forage trays filled with hay and buried treats. Offer hay in multiple locations and presentations so eating stays an activity.

Hides, Tunnels & Security

As prey animals, guinea pigs need multiple covered spaces with more than one exit. Provide at least two hide houses or tunnels per pig, spaced so animals can move between them. Cardboard boxes with two or more openings, fleece tunnels, wooden hideouts, and hay-stuffed grass tunnels all work. Avoid fully enclosed plastic igloos in warm weather (heat retention). Arrange the enclosure with distinct zones: open run space, hay/forage area, and quiet hide corners.

Chewing & Dental Wear

Teeth grow continuously. Offer untreated apple or willow twigs (bark left on), cardboard, plain paper, hay-based chew toys, and seagrass or willow balls. Avoid cherry wood, treated lumber, glue, staples, tape, and plastic coatings. Rotate chew items so interest stays high.

Social Companionship & Floor Time

Guinea pigs are highly social. A lone pig is at elevated risk of depression even with excellent human attention - plan for a compatible pair or small group. Provide daily supervised floor time in a pig-proofed area with tunnels, hides, and scattered forage so exercise and mental work happen together. Low ramps (max about 10 cm) are optional; pigs are not natural climbers and high drops risk injury. Rotate toys and rearrange hides every 1-3 weeks to maintain novelty without constant upheaval.

3. Health & Common Issues

Guinea pigs mask illness until they are quite sick. The highest-impact preventable problems are vitamin C deficiency (scurvy), dental disease from inadequate hay, GI stasis, respiratory infections, and issues caused by poor flooring or bedding. Know your baseline (weight, appetite, droppings) so changes stand out.

Red Flags - Contact a Vet Promptly

- Refusal to eat, or very small / absent droppings (possible GI stasis - same day)
- Drooling, weight loss, difficulty chewing (dental disease)
- Labored breathing, nasal or eye discharge, persistent sneezing
- Lethargy, hunched posture, rough coat
- Itching, hair loss, flaky skin (mites or ringworm - some are zoonotic)
- Swollen joints, bleeding gums, slow wound healing (possible scurvy)

Tell the vet recent diet (hay, pellets, veggies), weight trend, enclosure setup, and when symptoms started. Find a cavy-savvy exotic vet before an emergency.

Symptom Quick Reference

Sign	Possible concern	Action
No eating / no stool	GI stasis	Same-day vet
Drooling, weight loss	Dental disease	Exotic vet soon
Labored breathing	Respiratory infection	Prompt vet
Rough coat, poor healing	Possible scurvy	Vet + fix diet now
Itch, hair loss	Mites / ringworm	Vet (zoonotic risk)

Vitamin C Deficiency (Scurvy)

Guinea pigs cannot synthesize vitamin C. Without daily intake, immune function, wound healing, and bone/tooth development suffer. Prevention is dietary: fresh bell pepper and other high-C greens every day. Fortified pellets help but are not enough alone. Water additives degrade rapidly and are unreliable.

Dental Disease

Cheek teeth can overgrow even when the front incisors look normal. Signs include drooling, weight loss, and unusually small droppings. Unlimited grass hay is the primary prevention. Chronic cases may need professional trimming under anesthesia. Annual dental checks with an exotic vet catch problems early.

GI Stasis

If a guinea pig stops eating and produces little or no stool, treat it as an emergency. Stasis can escalate quickly. Same-day veterinary care is appropriate - do not wait overnight to 'see if they improve.'

Respiratory Infections

Sneezing, nasal or eye discharge, and labored breathing need prompt care. Stress, drafts, poor ventilation, and dusty or aromatic bedding raise risk. Guinea pigs are obligate nasal breathers - a blocked nose is serious.

4. Quick Reference & Checklist

Essential setup checklist

- Enclosure with 10-13+ sq ft continuous floor space for a pair (solid floor)
 - Fleece or paper bedding - no cedar/pine, no wire floor
 - At least one hide per pig plus one extra
 - Unlimited grass hay (Timothy/orchard/meadow) in rack or piles
 - Vitamin C-fortified pellets measured daily
 - Daily fresh vegetables (bell pepper recommended)
 - Water bottle or heavy bowl, cleaned regularly
 - Safe chew items (apple/willow twigs, cardboard)
 - Plan for a compatible companion
 - Cavy-experienced exotic vet identified
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Climate quick targets

Target	Value
Room temperature	65-75°F
Avoid	Above ~80°F; cold drafts
Floor space (pair)	10-13+ sq ft continuous
Vitamin C	Daily fresh veggies (e.g. bell pepper)
Hay	Unlimited grass hay always available

Emergency & Quick Targets - Guinea Pig

Print this page and keep it near the enclosure. When something looks wrong, start here.

Quick Targets

Parameter	Target
Room temperature	65-75°F
Hard max	Avoid above 80°F - heat stroke risk
Floor space (pair)	10-13+ sq ft continuous
Vitamin C	Daily fresh veggies - cannot synthesize
Hay	Unlimited grass hay always available

Red Flags - Act Early

- Refusal to eat or very small / no droppings (GI stasis emergency)
- Drooling, weight loss, difficulty chewing (dental)
- Labored breathing, nasal/eye discharge, sneezing
- Lethargy, hunched posture, rough coat
- Itching, hair loss, flaky skin (mites / ringworm)
- Swollen joints, bleeding gums, poor wound healing (scurvy)

Do This Now

- If not eating / no stool - same-day exotic/cavy vet
- Photograph animal + enclosure; note diet and recent changes
- Ensure unlimited hay + vitamin-C veggies are available immediately

Full symptom triage table (sign → concern → action) is in **3. Health & Common Issues**.

5. Owner Tools & Decision Guides

Budget tiers (pair, approximate)

Tier	Upfront	Monthly
Lean	\$100-150	\$60-90
Solid	\$150-220	\$90-120
Premium	\$220-300+	\$120-135+

Shopping List

- Solid-floor enclosure (C and C or similar) with 10-13+ sq ft for a pair
- Fleece liners or paper-based bedding (no cedar/pine)
- Hides and tunnels - at least one per pig plus one extra
- Hay rack or large hay piles
- Ceramic food dishes + water bottle or heavy bowl
- Vitamin C-fortified timothy-based pellets
- Ongoing Timothy/orchard/meadow hay supply
- Weekly fresh vegetables plan (bell peppers, leafy greens)
- Apple or willow chew sticks
- Carrier for vet visits
- Digital kitchen scale for weight checks
- Budget for exotic/cavy vet wellness exam

Item	Approx.
Enclosure (pair)	\$100-140
Bedding, dishes, hides (starter)	\$30-60
Hay (pair, monthly)	\$40-60
Pellets (pair, monthly)	\$15-30
Fresh vegetables (pair, monthly)	\$20-50
Annual wellness exam	\$50-100

First 30 Days

- Days 1-3: Quiet settling. Unlimited hay, measured pellets, introduce veggies gradually. Minimal handling beyond necessary care.
 - Days 4-7: Begin short gentle handling sessions. Confirm both pigs (if pair) are eating and producing normal droppings. Weigh and record baseline.
 - Week 2: Establish floor-time routine. Rotate one enrichment item. Confirm vitamin C veggies are accepted daily.
 - Week 3-4: Full daily/weekly routine. Schedule or confirm exotic vet wellness visit. Review weight trend.
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Daily & Weekly Routine

Print this page and post it near the enclosure. Check boxes as you go. Use the date lines to track consistency.

Daily

- Refresh unlimited hay
 - Measured pellets (remove uneaten)
 - Fresh vitamin C vegetables (e.g. bell pepper)
 - Fresh water; quick spot-clean wet bedding
 - Visual health check (eyes, nose, posture, appetite)
 - Brief gentle interaction / floor time if schedule allows
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Weekly

- Full bedding change / fleece wash as needed
 - Wash dishes and water bottle thoroughly
 - Weigh each pig and log the number
 - Rotate one enrichment item or rearrange a hide
 - Check chews and replace worn cardboard/wood
 - Inspect for mites, sores on feet, coat quality
-

Monthly / ongoing

- Review weight trend over the past month
- Deep-clean enclosure corners and accessories
- Confirm vet contact info is current
- Reassess pair dynamics and space if adding pigs later

Week of: _____ Initials: _____

Week of: _____ Initials: _____

Week of: _____ Initials: _____

Owner Log - Guinea Pig

Track weight and basic daily notes. Weight change is often the earliest warning sign. Print extra copies as needed.

Weight & Daily Log

Date	Weight (g)	Ate?	Stool?	Notes

Vitamin C & GI Stasis Notes

- Guinea pigs cannot make vitamin C. Daily bell pepper or other high-C greens are non-negotiable - do not rely only on fortified pellets or water drops.
- Any refusal to eat plus reduced or absent droppings is a same-day emergency (GI stasis). Do not wait overnight.
- Wire-bottom cages and cedar/pine shavings are never acceptable - use solid floors and paper or fleece bedding.
- Find a cavy-experienced exotic vet before you need one.

Enrichment Checklist - Guinea Pig

Enrichment is not optional decoration. Use this as a setup and monthly review checklist.

Setup & Ongoing Checklist

- Scatter pellets and veg through hay instead of bowl-only feeding
- Cardboard tubes stuffed with hay and greens (slit lengthwise)
- Multiple hides and tunnels with two exits each
- Untreated apple or willow twigs for continuous chewing
- Snuffle mat or forage tray with buried treats
- Daily supervised floor time with scattered hay
- Compatible pair or group - never long-term solitary
- Rotate toys and rearrange hides every 1-3 weeks

Monthly review notes (write in):

Date: _____ What changed: _____

Date: _____ What changed: _____

Date: _____ What changed: _____

Rule: stability for core hides/heat/water systems; novelty only in non-critical items.

Glossary

Bumblefoot. Painful sores on the feet, often from wire floors or dirty, hard surfaces.

C and C cage. Cubes-and-coroplast style enclosure popular for guinea pigs; modular and solid-floored.

GI stasis. Slowdown or stoppage of gut movement; emergency when paired with appetite loss and reduced droppings.

Popcorning. Sudden vertical leaps and twists - a happy play behavior.

Scurvy. Vitamin C deficiency; guinea pigs cannot synthesize vitamin C.

Timothy hay. Common adult grass hay used for fiber, dental wear, and gut health.

Wheek. Loud excited vocalization, often for food or attention.

This care package was compiled from BeastlyFacts research and practical husbandry standards.

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Disclaimer: This package is for educational purposes and is not a substitute for veterinary care. Husbandry standards evolve; always verify critical health decisions with a qualified exotic veterinarian.

No external links are included in this document.
